

Time to redefine cheating

I find myself contemplating, as I watch my sixth-grade daughter wrestle with fractions and mathematical word problems. Maths isn't her strongest subject, and she hasn't asked for AI help – yet. But as I glance at her laptop screen, I can't shake the thought of Cluely, the “undetectable” assistant that whispers answers during job interviews, exams and even first dates. The very possibility that an AI could stealthily guide her through long division feels like a revelation – and a reckoning.

Cluely exploded into public consciousness this year under the slogan “We want to cheat on everything.” Born from a campus hack that secretly injected coding answers into live technical assessments, it's an AI tool that now promises real-time suggestions for other high-stakes scenarios. I haven't used it, witnessed it in action, and my understanding of Cluely's is limited to articles, videos and heated online debates. Yet imagining my daughter opening a hidden browser tab for AI cues feels eerily plausible.

Naturally, it makes me wonder what it means for the dissolving of the boundary between assistance and cheating? Traditional education, as we know it (as I grew up through school back in the '90s) relies on memorization and timed quizzes, where every correct answer is supposed to represent genuine comprehension. But when an AI starts murmuring the next step in a proof or a solution to a science question, it starts to dismantle what we and our education system has come to define as mastery in any subject. But then again, how is this any different from autocorrect or calculators?

Calculators once sparked similar moral panic. When they first appeared in classrooms, educators fretted that students would lose basic arithmetic skills. But today, we take them for granted. However, I know that AI assistance isn't just about arithmetic – it can craft arguments, optimize sales pitches, even navigate social interactions. If my daughter someday uses a Cluely-style tool for her homework, will we celebrate her efficiency or lament her dependence?



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I imagine parents weighing choices: permit AI aids and focus on interpretation, or ban them and risk driving students into secret workarounds. PTA meetings on this topic would be interesting to see. Will we create honour codes for AI, enforcing where prompts end and original thought begins? Or will we rewrite assessments to value processes, asking students to articulate how AI suggestions shaped their ultimate understanding of any concept or topic?

At home, my biggest question is how to guide my daughter in this uncertain future. I also understand that this dilemma isn't just of a father trying to weigh the pros and cons of cutting-edge tech in his daughter's life. Society itself is at a crossroads in its attempts to adjust to the new AI normal.

I think the choice boils down to this: We can either cling to old paradigms – policing screens, tightening measures, outlawing AI companions – or we can embrace the reality that assistance has evolved. AI prompts will be as ubiquitous as search engines, and the real challenge lies in distinguishing between assistance that empowers from shortcuts that diminish understanding.

Cluely's audacious marketing may ultimately fade, but the questions it raises will endure. As I contemplate my daughter's future, I realize the lesson isn't about policing tools anymore – it's about teaching adaptability. We must help the next generation learn how to learn, to interrogate AI outputs, to recognize when a hint clarifies versus when it obscures, and to cultivate the confidence that comes from authentic problem-solving.

In the end, the echo of cheating AI, I feel, is an opportunity to reimagine education. We need to recalibrate merit and prepare our children and the younger generation for a world where every answer can be whispered by an algorithm. And perhaps, through thoughtful dialogue and intentional experimentation, we'll discover that the true measure of mastery (or even honesty for that matter) lies not in secret shortcuts, but in the attempt to question, explore and recognise one's own self-growth. **d**



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